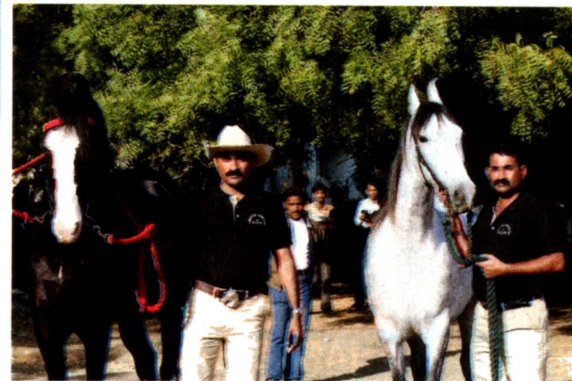


Like other parts of the country, owning a horse has become a status symbol in Gujarat. Suddenly, not just the old Kathi families of rural areas but many new generation business families in cities like Ahmedabad and Vadodara are taking a keen interest in horse riding. Some of them are even turning horse breeders. The credit for this turnaround mainly goes to the efforts of some of the old horse breeding families and their organisations which encourage interest in the two local breeds. Anish Gajjar, scion of a corporate family and a horse breeder, has started a local horse society in Ahmedabad which offers lodging facility to those horse lovers who want to own horses but don't have the facility to maintain it. "There is altogether a new class of horse lovers that has emerged in Gujarat," he says. Adds Gajendrapal Singh Posana, an expert on the local breeds of the animal from Rajasthan: "The best part is that the new generation not only takes pride in owning a horse but pleasure in riding it too." According to Gajjar, the total number of horse owners in Ahmedabad has more than trebled in the past eight years.

Simultaneously, the state Government has sharpened its focus on indigenous horse breeding by organising horse shows, giving special help to committed private breeders and making a serious effort to encourage the use and breeding of Kathiawadi and Marwadi horses. At the behest of the state Government, a research project was taken up by the Saurashtra University on how to revive the Kathiawadi breed. The project, in which the best experts of Kathiawadi breed in Gujarat involved, also dwelled on its relationship with the Marwadi breed. The two breeds differ in physiognomy. The face of the Kathiawadi breed, which is said to have Arab blood, is small. Its ears are small and curled. There's a curve on the face of the Kathiawadi breed while that of Marwadi is straight. And a Marwadi



(LEFT) MARWADI STALLION SHAKTI WAS DECLARED THE BEST HORSE OVERALL; THE BEST HORSES IN THE KATHIAWADI (ABOVE) AND MARWADI CATEGORIES (BELOW)



horse is taller than Kathiawadi. The Kathiawadi horse revival project is now searching for all the ancient written material available, particularly from old royal families. Says Ramkubhai Khachar, who is a member of the committee overseeing the research project, "This is indeed a major step aimed at reviving a local breed and a lesson for all those in the country who are thinking of reviving local horse breeds."

There are many local horse breeds across the country that have disappeared. For example, the great Maratha warrior Yashwantrao Holkar fought many battles riding on his famous mare Mahua, which was of the Bhimthadi breed from Maharashtra. The breed is almost extinct and so is another Maha-

ashtra breed called Gunthadi. Says Ghanshyamdasji Maharaj: "Our aim is to involve like-minded people as well as the Government and set an example that will inspire many others in saving local horse breeds across the country." The popular response to the horse shows and the increase in the numbers of the two breeds are not the only yardsticks indicating change. One Marwadi mare called Shivpyari, bred at the stud farm of Mahesh Patel, fetched Rs 16 lakh recently, something unthinkable a few years ago. Elsewhere, there are encouraging signs as well. Last month, the Punjab Government announced prizes worth Rs 1.5 crore at a horse show, the highest so far. Indigenous horses are literally riding high once again. ■